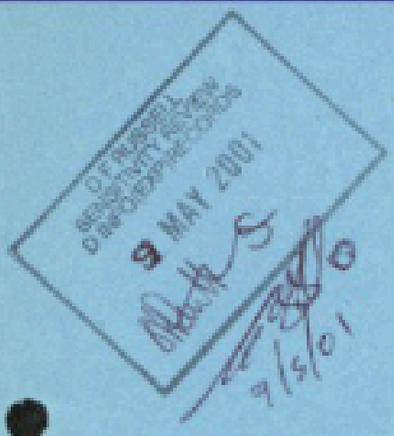
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MINISTRY OF DEFENCE

DIRECTORATE OF

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JOINT TECHNICAL INTELLIGENCE COMMITTEE

DEFE 44/119

UNIDENTIFIED FLYING OBJECTS

June 1951

D.S.I./J.T.I.C. REPORT No. 7

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aircraft," and that a series of " shadows " appeared in the space between successive points.

As the receding course of the radar target could have tallied with the course of the object reported by the Meteor pilot, all the people concerned were interviewed by a member of Research Branch, Fighter Command, from whose report the above data have been taken. It was established that there was in fact a discrepancy of ten minutes between the times of the two reports, which were estimated as individually accurate to ± 1 minute. It must therefore be concluded that there was no connection between the unusual P.P.I. response and the pilot's visual observation.

We believe that the radar response can be very simply explained as due to interference from another transmitter, a phenomenon which has been frequently observed, and which is described in detail in Appendix A. It is impossible to be entirely definite about the pilot's report. Assuming that he was not merely the victim of an optical illusion, the most probable explanation, which is borne out by his description of the object as " circular," implying a spherical body, is that he saw a meteorological balloon and greatly over-estimated its speed. We can find no reason whatever for adopting any less simple hypothesis.

13. The remaining two incidents were reported from the Royal Aircraft Establishment, Farnborough, and the officers concerned were interviewed by members of this Working Party.

F/Lt. Hubbard, an experienced pilot, said that at 1127 on 14th August, 1950, he and two other officers on the airfield heard a subdued humming noise, like a model Diesel motor, which caused them to search the sky overhead. The weather was fine and visibility good. The other two officers saw nothing, but F/Lt. Hubbard, who alone was wearing sun-glasses, states that he saw, almost directly overhead at first sighting, an object which he describes as a flat disc, light pearl grey in colour, about 50 feet in diameter at an estimated height of 5,000 feet. He stated that he kept it under observation for 30 seconds, during which period it travelled, at a speed estimated at 800–1,000 m.p.h., on a heading of 100°, executing a series of S-turns, oscillating so that light reflection came from different segments as it moved.

We have no reason to doubt that F/Lt. Hubbard honestly described his own impression of what he saw, but we find it impossible to believe that a most unconventional aircraft, of exceptional speed, could have travelled at no great altitude, in the middle of a fine summer morning, over a populous and air-minded district like Farnborough, without attracting the attention of more than one observer. We conclude, either that F/Lt. Hubbard was the victim of an optical illusion, or that he observed some quite normal type of aircraft and deceived himself about its shape and speed.

14. F/Lt. Hubbard was also concerned in the other incident, when, at 1609 on 5th September, 1950, he was standing on the watch-tower with five other officers, looking south in anticipation of the display by the Hawker 1081. The sky was about 3/8 obscured, with a strato-cumulus cloud base at 4,000 feet. At about the same moment they all saw, at an estimated range of 10–15 miles, an object which they described as being a flat disc, light pearl grey in colour, and " about the size of a shirt button." They all observed it to follow a rectangular flight path, consisting in succession of a " falling leaf," horizontal flight " very fast," an upward " falling leaf," another horizontal stretch, and so on; finally it dived to the horizon at great speed. The pattern was estimated to be executed somewhere over the Guildford–Farnham area.

F/Lt. Hubbard was satisfied that the objects he saw on the two occasions were identical; the other observers agreed that the second object fitted the description they had been given of the first.

We have no doubt that all these officers did in fact see a flying object of some sort. We cannot, however regard the evidence of identification of this object, which was only seen at very long range, with the earlier one as of any value whatever. Further, we again find it impossible to believe that an unconventional aircraft, manœuvring for some time over a populous area, could have failed to attract the attention of other observers. We conclude that the officers in fact saw some quite normal aircraft, manœuvring at extreme visual range, and were led by the previous report to believe it to be something abnormal—an interesting example of one report inducing another. We are reinforced in this belief by an experience of one of our number (Wing Commander Formby, R.A.F.) which is recounted in Appendix B and illustrates the ease with which mistaken identifications may be made, even by experienced observers.

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